



Ages 14 to 18

Looking After Yourself and Your Friends: Self-Harm and Suicidal Thoughts

Noticing how you feel, coping, getting help, and supporting a friend without carrying it alone.
For all students.

Before You Read This guide covers self-harm and suicidal thoughts.

This guide is about self-harm and suicidal thoughts: noticing them, coping, getting help, and supporting a friend. It doesn't describe methods or anything graphic, but some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something you're going through or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time. **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains what self-harm and suicidal thoughts are, how to look after yourself, what happens if you tell someone, and how to support a friend without carrying it all yourself.

- Self-harm and suicidal thoughts can affect **anyone**, whatever their gender, background, grades or how they seem on the outside.
- They are signs that someone is in pain and needs support. They are **not** attention-seeking, and they are **nothing to be ashamed of**.
- Suicide is preventable. Feelings this strong can change, and **help works**.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If you feel you might act on thoughts of suicide, or you've hurt yourself and need help, **tell an adult now**, call **Samaritans** free on 116 123, or text **SHOUT** to 85258.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Self-harm

Hurting yourself on purpose, usually to cope with overwhelming feelings such as distress, anger, numbness or shame. It can bring short-term relief, which is why it can be hard to stop.

Suicidal thoughts

Thoughts about not wanting to be alive, or about ending your life. They can come and go, and they can pass.

Crisis

A point where you feel you can't cope or can't keep yourself safe. That's the time to get help straight away.

Safety plan

A personal plan, made with someone you trust: your warning signs, what helps, reasons to hold on, and who to contact.

Mental health services

NHS services for young people (often called CAMHS). The school, your GP or another professional can refer you.

You're Not the Only One

24.1%

of 17-year-olds in the UK had self-harmed in the previous 12 months

Patalay and Fitzsimons, 2021 (10,103 17-year-olds, UK)

1 in 5

8 to 16 year olds in England had a probable mental disorder in 2023

NHS England, 2023

These figures are not a reason to worry more. They show that struggling is common, and that asking for help is normal. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Patalay and Fitzsimons, *Psychological distress, self-harm and attempted suicide in UK 17-year olds*, British Journal of Psychiatry (2021), Millennium Cohort Study
- NHS England, *One in five children and young people had a probable mental disorder in 2023*

Noticing How You Feel

Warning Signs in Yourself

- Feeling hopeless, trapped, numb or like a burden
- Pulling away from friends, or stopping things you used to enjoy
- Sleeping badly, or much more than usual
- Urges to hurt yourself when feelings get too much
- Thinking more and more about not being here

Worth Remembering

- Feelings, even the heaviest ones, change over time
- You don't need to be sure it's "bad enough" to ask for help
- Getting help early makes things easier to turn around
- Talking about it is a strength, not a weakness

Coping and Getting Help

- **Tell someone.** A friend, a family member, or an adult at school. If saying it is too hard, write it down or show them this guide.
- **Get through the moment.** Slow breathing (out for longer than in), cold water on your face, moving your body, music, or going somewhere with other people around.

- **Delay.** If you have an urge to hurt yourself, try putting it off for a few minutes, then a few more, while you do something else or contact someone. Urges often pass.
- **Make a safety plan** with someone you trust. Stay Alive app (Grassroots Suicide Prevention): free, with a personal safety plan and a directory of help (prevent-suicide.org.uk).
- **Use professional support.** The school counsellor, your GP, or NHS mental health services can help you find ways of coping that work for you, and deal with what sits underneath.

If You've Hurt Yourself

If you have an injury, get it looked at: the school nurse, a first aider, or your GP. **Call 999** if an injury is serious, or if you have taken too much of any medicine or swallowed something harmful, even if you feel fine. You won't be judged or told off.

If You're Having Thoughts of Suicide

Right Now

- **You don't have to act on these thoughts**, and you don't have to cope with them on your own.
- **Tell someone today:** an adult at school, a family member, or a friend who can help you tell an adult.
- **If you feel you can't keep yourself safe**, call 999 or go to A&E, or ask someone to take you.
- **If you need urgent help that isn't an emergency**, call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online.
- **Talk to someone now:** Childline 0800 1111 (under 19), Samaritans 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258. All free, any time.
- Put some distance between yourself and anything you could use to hurt yourself, and be around other people.

Exams and Pressure

- Exams matter, but **you matter more**. There is always another route: resits, different courses, different paths.

- If you're struggling, tell someone **before** the exam, not after. Schools can sometimes make arrangements, such as rest breaks or a separate room, and exam boards have rules for when something serious affects you.
- Results day can bring big feelings, good or bad. Plan who you'll be with, and who you can call.

RESPOND: Supporting a Friend

Young people often tell a friend before they tell an adult. That makes you part of how people get help. But **you are not expected to keep your friend safe on your own**, and you shouldn't try. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and **adults lead the systems steps**.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Withdrawal, hopelessness, talking about being a burden or not being around, giving things away, hiding injuries
- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (what's changed?), **Places** (where do they seem worst?), **Platforms** (posts or messages?), **Patterns** (is it getting worse?)
- You don't need certainty to act

E

Engage

Ask. Listen.

- "I've noticed you've not been yourself. I'm worried about you."
- Ask directly: "Are you thinking about suicide?" It won't put the idea in their head, and it shows you can handle the answer
- Listen without judging or trying to fix it



Support

Stay close.

- "Thank you for telling me. You're not a burden."
- If they may be in danger right now, stay with them if it is safe to do so, and get an adult or call 999

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Slow down before you act.

- Three questions: **Risk** (are they in danger now?), **Rights** (what do they need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- Don't promise to keep it secret. A friend's life matters more than a promise
- You're not expected to monitor them, check on injuries, or manage it yourself. That is the adults' job

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- "Let's talk to someone together. I'll come with you."
- Share the numbers in this guide



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- **Tell a trusted adult, even if your friend asks you not to.** Tell your friend what you're going to do, if you can
- If they talk about ending their life, or have hurt themselves seriously, tell an adult straight away, or call 999 if they're in danger now
- If it's late at night and you're worried, call 999 if they're in danger, or tell a parent or, if you board, a member of staff
- It isn't betraying them. It's how they get help



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Tell them clearly what you saw and heard, including any messages

Look After Yourself Too

Supporting a friend can be exhausting and frightening. It's not your fault if they are struggling, and it's not your job to fix it. Talk to an adult about how **you** are doing too.



If You Tell Someone

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- If you've hurt yourself, the school nurse can check injuries privately and without judgement.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

What to Expect

- You won't be in trouble for self-harm or for having suicidal thoughts.

- Your parents or carers will usually be told when there is a risk to your safety. The adults will talk with you about how, and will think carefully first if there is something at home that makes this harder.
- You may be offered support in school, a safety plan, and a referral to NHS mental health services.
- If the first person you tell doesn't help, tell someone else.

Whoever You Are

- LGBTQ+ young people can face extra pressures, such as bullying or not feeling accepted. That's not because of who they are, and support is there. Adults won't share your identity with others, including your family, without thinking carefully and talking to you.
- If you're autistic or neurodivergent, it's OK to explain things in your own way, in writing, or with someone who knows you well.

Online

- Some online content about self-harm or suicide can make you feel worse, or pull you in. If something upsets you, **close it, don't share it, and tell someone**. Report it on the platform.
- **Don't share images of injuries**, and don't pass on posts about someone else's self-harm or suicidal thoughts. Tell an adult instead.
- If a friend posts or messages something that worries you, **tell an adult straight away**. If they may be in danger now, call 999.
- If someone dies, don't share details or speculation online. It can put others at risk.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Asking about suicide puts the idea in someone's head"	Asking directly can protect someone. It gives them permission to talk, and shows they're not a burden.

"Self-harm is attention-seeking"	Most self-harm is hidden. It's usually a way of coping with overwhelming feelings, and a sign someone needs support.
"People who talk about suicide won't act on it"	Anyone who talks about wanting to die should be taken seriously and helped.
"If I tell, I'll lose my friend"	It can feel that way. But their safety matters more than a secret, and getting them help is what a good friend does.
"It's my job to keep my friend safe"	It isn't. Your job is to tell an adult. Keeping someone safe is the adults' job.
"Nothing can help"	Feelings change, and support works. With the right help, things can get better, even when that is hard to believe.



If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If you're struggling at night, or you're worried about someone in your house, tell a member of staff straight away, **even in the middle of the night.**
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.



Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free from any phone, any time, day or night, whatever your age
- **NHS 111:** call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online
- **Stay Alive app (Grassroots Suicide Prevention):** free, with a personal safety plan and a directory of help
- If you're 18 or over: CALM (for adults, 18 and over): 0800 58 58 58, 5pm to midnight every day, or webchat at [thecalmzone.net](https://www.thecalmzone.net)
- **Emergency:** call 999

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Looking After Yourself and Your Friends: Student Guide 34 - 14 to 18

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